

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 65

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1958-1964

Coverage Date: Ca. 1958-1964

Place Coverage: G/Wi San, Botswana

Section Title(S)

(3) Behaviour Patterns. • (5) The Effects of the System. • 4. Joking Relationship.

Elder brothers are also treated with respect. Younger brothers are expected to be somewhat subservient and to do whatever they are asked. On the other hand, the elder brother has to look after the younger and help and advise him in a rather paternal sort of way.

593
[Family Relationships](#)

The G/wi are polygamous, and a man is expected to take his brother's widow and children as his own if the brother should die. He is also expected to marry her if the brother should divorce her. Besides this form of levirate, a sororate also exists; a man should take his wife's sister as an additional wife, if she has lost her husband through death or divorce, and her children are taken as the man's own children. It is for this reason that one terms one's parallel cousins "siblings" and their parents are called "step-parents"; because the uncles and aunts are, in fact, potential step-parents and their children are potential half-brothers and -sisters. The extent to which this arrangement holds good is seen in the fact that the spouses of male parallel cousins (terminologically one's brothers) may, like one's real brother's wife, be termed "wife".

587
[Secondary Marriages](#)

595
[Polygamy](#)

601
[Kinship Terminology](#)

4. *Joking Relationship.*

Another aspect of the behaviour patterns prescribed in the G/wi kinship system is the joking relationship. All kin are in either the joking or the avoidance categories and the behaviour is reciprocal, i.e. if I am in a cousin's joking category, he is also in mine. Joking partners may behave very freely with each other. Mutual teasing, insults, practical jokes and free use of each

602
[Kin Relationships](#)

other's property are all permitted, in fact this is expected of joking partners, and no offence is ever taken nor is resentment felt. These aggressive elements of the relationship are of less importance than the co-operative and friendly aspects, for it is among one's joking partners than one seeks one's friends. Men in this category hunt together and help with other co-operative undertakings and go together on visits to other bands. These activities are not confined to joking partners, but may also be shared by friends who are not related to each other and who are therefore neither joking nor avoidance partners. Women gather plants together, gossip, sing and dance with each other. A young man and a girl who are joking partners and of the appropriate ages are considered potential marriage partners.

The avoidance relationship, however, is characterised by great reserve and respect. Towards persons older than oneself, one uses the honorific dual when addressing them. The possessions of these relatives are not even touched without prior permission, and marriage between persons in the avoidance category would be considered incestuous.

601
Kinship Terminology

602
Kin Relationships

It is interesting to note the principle of alternation of generations in joking/avoidance relationships; if A is B's joking partner, then A's children and parents (i.e. his two proximate generations) will be in the avoidance category *vis-a-vis* B, while the grandparents and grandchildren will be in the joking category. Were this not so, it would lead to embarrassing triangular relationships in which B could joke with A's avoidance kin in the presence of A.

602
Kin Relationships

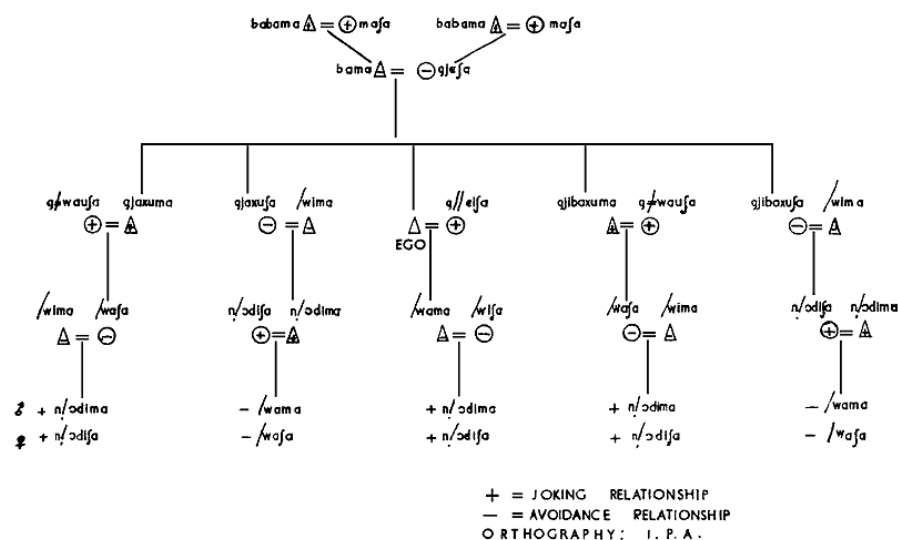
(5) *The Effects of the System.*

By classifying all recognised kin and imposing patterns of behaviour towards each, the G/wi kinship system provides the individual with a  66

601
Kinship Terminology

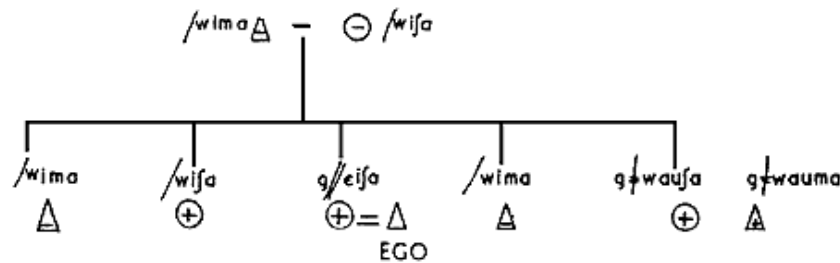
602
Kin Relationships

G/wi Kinship Terminology



G/wi Kinship Terminology

AFFINES



ready-made series of relationships in which he knows his place and can accurately anticipate the behaviour of others and their reactions to his behaviour. As these people constitute a large part of his social milieu, he is relieved of the often wasteful and painful task of establishing and maintaining these relationships for himself. In such a random arrangement of relationships, there is danger of jealousies and conflicts arising through an individual's coming between two friends or of his disturbing the enmities and possibly intensifying them by becoming friendly with two persons who are not on good terms with one another. The G/wi are far too occupied with their battle with their environment to be able to afford the disintegration of co-operative effort which would result from unresolved conflicts which would arise between people living together and having to share means and goods which are seldom sufficient to satisfy the wants of all.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: [✉ hraf@yale.edu](mailto:hraf@yale.edu)

Issues and Bugs: [✉ hraf-support@yale.edu](mailto:hraf-support@yale.edu)



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)